



aerodynamic improvements, and found military uses during World War II. But “soaring flight” has remained perhaps the purest of aerial activities, only marginally involved with commerce or war.

The idea of flying an aircraft as an activity open to millions has remained one of the frustrated dreams of aviation. As early as 1924

American automobile manufacturer Henry Ford envisaged a future in which aircraft would be produced in similar numbers to cars. In the 1930s American air administrator Eugene Vidal was a prominent campaigner for a “poor man’s airplane,” a Model T Ford of the air, that would transform flying from “a rich man’s hobby to a

daily utility or inexpensive pleasure for the average American citizen.” From the 1920s onward, private aviation in light aircraft did become a popular sport open to the moderately affluent. But the notion of an aircraft parked in every driveway never came off.

There were several attempts to produce flying cars – vehicles that could be driven on roads as well as fly through the air. Perhaps the most promising was Molt Taylor’s Aerocar, produced in the 1950s. The flying surfaces folded up to turn the airplane into an automobile; the engine drove a propeller when in aircraft mode and the wheels when it was being driven on the ground. But the Aerocar’s dual function involved too many compromises to perform well enough in either genre.

There were also attempts at making aviation very cheap, of which perhaps the most memorable was Frenchman Henri Mignet’s Pou du Ciel, or Flying Flea. Brought out in 1933, this tiny aircraft was sold in kit form, to be assembled at home. After some 30 days’ hard work, the purchaser would have a machine capable of reaching 80mph (130kph), but with a landing speed of only 19mph (30kph). The Flying Flea was greeted with a rush of enthusiasm, but despite Mignet’s claim that it



FLYING CAR

Molt Taylor's Aerocar, marketed in the 1950s, was one of the most ambitious efforts to create an aircraft for people to keep in their garage. It is shown here in both flight and automobile mode – the wings are folded up in the trailer.

